

A general-purpose agent can help a student summarise a chapter, a journalist analyse an interview transcript, a freelancer draft a proposal, or a family plan a holiday. Its biggest strength is flexibility. Its biggest weakness is that it may not be deeply connected to the apps where your work actually happens.

2. Productivity agents

The second category is the productivity agent. These live inside work apps such as Microsoft 365, Google Workspace, Gmail, Outlook, Teams, Docs, Sheets, Excel, Notion and Slack. Their advantage is context. They can work with your emails, documents, meetings and calendars. Their weakness is that they are only as useful as the ecosystem they live in.

If your office runs on Microsoft 365, Copilot-style workflows may be more useful than a separate chatbot. If your life is in Google Drive and Gmail, Gemini-style integrations may feel more natural. If your team lives in Notion, Slack or Teams, an agent inside those tools may save more time than a powerful but separate assistant.

3. Automation agents

The third category is the automation agent. These connect different apps together. Think of workflows such as: when a form is submitted, classify the lead, add it to a spreadsheet, draft a reply, notify the sales team and create a follow-up reminder.

Tools such as Zapier, Make, n8n, Power Automate and similar platforms are useful here. They are not always glamorous, but they are often the difference between “AI gave me an idea” and “AI saved me two hours every day.”

Automation agents are ideal when the task is repetitive, rule-based and spread across apps. For example, a coaching class can use one to capture enquiries, categorise them by course, draft replies and remind the counsellor to call hot leads.



4. Coding and app-building agents

The fourth category is the coding and app-building agent. These are meant for developers, students, tech teams and ambitious non-coders. They can generate code, explain errors, modify files, create prototypes, write tests and build small internal tools.

GitHub Copilot, Codex-style tools, Claude Code, Gemini coding tools, Cursor-like editors and agent-first development environments belong here. Use them when the output is code, an app, a script, a website, a dashboard or a technical workflow.

For non-developers, this category is exciting but risky. It may help you build a basic expense tracker, college event registration form, internal reporting dashboard or landing page. But you still need to test everything. Code that looks polished can still be insecure, broken or impossible to maintain.

5. Business-platform agents

The fifth category is the business-platform agent. These are agents inside enterprise systems such as Salesforce, ServiceNow, HubSpot, Zoho, Freshworks and CRM or support platforms. Their purpose is not generic conversation. Their purpose is to support business processes: sales follow-ups, customer support, ticket classification, marketing journeys, knowledge-base answers, HR workflows and operational reporting.

For Indian SMEs, this category is especially interesting because even small teams now handle large volumes of customer messages, leads, invoices and service requests. A five-person business can look much larger and more responsive if routine replies, reminders and classifications are handled well.

6. Local or private agents

The sixth category is the local or private agent. These run on your own device, your own server, or a controlled enterprise environment. They may use local models, private document stores, on-premise deployments or restricted cloud setups.

They are relevant when privacy, compliance, latency or data sovereignty matter. A lawyer, doctor, journalist, school administrator, fintech team or government contractor should think carefully before uploading sensitive documents into any public tool. Sometimes the best agent is the one that cannot freely leak your data because it never had unnecessary access in the first place.

Start with low-risk tasks

For beginners, the safest starting point is a general-purpose assistant with file analysis. Upload a non-sensitive PDF, spreadsheet or set of notes, then ask the agent to summarise, classify, compare and produce a table.

A college student can upload a syllabus and ask for a four-week revision plan. A journalist can upload an interview transcript and ask for themes, quote clusters and unanswered questions. A freelancer can upload a client brief and ask for deliverables, deadlines and risks. In each case, the agent is useful without needing dangerous permissions.

Move next to productivity integration

The next step is productivity integration. If you already use Gmail, Google Calendar, Microsoft Outlook, Teams, Docs, Excel